DEMOCRACY MATTERS

Democracy Matters

Today’s Special Topic: Elections

TODAY +★

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Civics & Basic Concepts

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Communication & Social Media

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Action & Mobilisation

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☆☆☆ are the slots per pillar. Everyone collects their own — My DM shows where you stand.

1 · Special Topic 30′
Elections — the sprint

2 · The round
Discussion & wind-down

Fri, 6 November 2026 · 3 PM · Room C2, Impact Hub · Members and guests welcome

SPECIAL TOPIC

Elections

Brazil, Serbia, USA: what an election decides, and who believes the result

Warm-up	Experiment	Three cases	Discussion	Take-away
5′	5′	7′	5′	5′

Why this topic? Within 30 days, Brazil, Serbia and the USA all vote. Same word, very different decisions. And the same question everywhere: who believes the result?

Sprint
30m

1 — WARM-UP

Phones out



Scan the QR, enter a name — three questions, everyone at once.

dmatters.org
Join — if the QR code acts up

Open the beamer view →
Host: starts the game and shows questions, answers, leaderboard

Time
5m

After each question: answer + explanation — the app does that.

2 — LIVE EXPERIMENT

An experiment with you

TWO REAL SYSTEMS, NO COUNTRY NAMES

“How much do you trust this result?”

1. The moderator hands out slips: **left** side of the room gets slip **A**, **right** side slip **B**.
2. Read your slip silently. **Don’t show it.**
3. Show with **1–5 fingers**: how much would you trust this result?

→ Next slide: which countries are they?

Slips to print

Not a test, no right or wrong. Two halves, two systems.

Time

5m

2 — THE CHECK

A was Brazil, B the USA

A · Brazil

Electronic, central, finished the same evening. Each machine can be checked online; there are no paper votes to recount.

B · USA

Many rules, local offices, nearly all on paper. Recounts are possible, but the uncertainty lasts days to weeks.

Plus: Serbia

Paper, counted at the polling station, parties on the polling boards, observers in the room. Still: widespread distrust of the voter register.

Checkable: can someone outside recalculate it?

Fair: were the chances equal before election day?

Accepted: do the losers recognise the result?

Sources: TSE · ODIHR/OSCE · Verified Voting and EAC via Brennan Center · Al Jazeera

Four questions for any election

What	What does it really decide?
How	What rules does it run on?
Stakes	What is at stake?
Trust	Who believes the result, and why?

Time
7m

All facts as of 30 October 2026. Sources: participant page.

CASE 1 · BRAZIL · 4 AND 25 OCTOBER 2026

Brazil: presidency and Congress on one day

What does it decide?

The presidency, all 513 seats in the Chamber of Deputies, 54 of 81 Senate seats, governors and state parliaments.

How does it work?

Presidency: more than 50% of valid votes, otherwise a runoff. Voting is compulsory for most adults. People vote on electronic machines.

What was at stake?

Who runs the country. First round: Flávio Bolsonaro 47.03%, Lula 45.16%. Runoff: Lula 51.79%, Bolsonaro 48.21%. Turnout 80.8%.

Who believes the result?



The electoral court TSE announced the result on election night. On 28 October Flávio Bolsonaro wrote of electoral fraud, pointing to the extended voting hours; according to CNN Brasil the letter offers no evidence. His party, the PL, recognises the result.

Inauguration scheduled: 5 January 2027.

Sources: TSE · Câmara dos Deputados · CNN Brasil · as of 30 Oct 2026

CASE 2 · SERBIA · 25 OCTOBER 2026

Serbia: early parliamentary election PRELIMINARY

What does it decide?

All 250 seats in parliament. With 126 seats a list has the majority, and parliament settles the government. The presidency is elected separately, by 27 December at the latest.

How does it work?

Proportional representation with closed lists; the whole country is one constituency. A 3% threshold applies, except for national minority lists.

What was at stake?

After the canopy collapse in Novi Sad that killed 16 (2024), the student movement demanded early elections. Preliminary: Student List about 53%, United Serbia (SNS) about 39%, turnout about 69%.

Who believes the result?

Vučić conceded on election night. The international observation mission (OSCE, Council of Europe, European Parliament) rates election day mostly positively but calls equal campaign opportunities seriously compromised. A repeat vote is set for 1 November at 53 polling stations.

Result to follow · Final result of the electoral commission Only after the repeat vote on 1 November.

Sources: ODIHR/OSCE · electoral commission RIK (via RTS, Danas) · Reuters · as of 30 Oct 2026

CASE 3 · USA · 3 NOVEMBER 2026

USA: Congress at half-time NOT OFFICIAL

What does it decide?

Congress, not the presidency: all 435 House seats, 35 of 100 Senate seats, plus 36 governors.

How does it work?

Each state has its own rules, and several redrew their districts. In June 2026 the Supreme Court ruled 5–4 that states may count mail ballots sent in time that arrive after Election Day.

What is at stake?

Who shapes the laws. Before the vote, House: Democrats 214, Republicans 218, 1 independent, 2 vacant. Senate: Democrats with 2 independents 47, Republicans 53. Majority: 218 and 51.

Who believes the result?

Open. One night is not enough: the count takes days to weeks, and early tallies can mislead.

House: Democrats 219 · Republicans 135 · still open 81 · Majority: Democrats

Senate: Democrats 54 · Republicans 43 · still open 3 · Majority: Democrats

Governors: Democrats 19 · Republicans 12 · still open 5

As of 04.11.2026, 09:10 · AP via NPR · Senate incl. 2 independents who caucus with the Democrats · House: Louisiana 5 goes to a runoff

Sources: Clerk of the House · Al Jazeera · Votebeat · Ballotpedia · as of 30 Oct 2026

3 — AND SWITZERLAND?

Here, less hangs on a single day

ELECTING

We elect parliament, not the government.

The Federal Council is elected by the Federal Assembly. The next federal elections are on 24 October 2027.

VOTING

Between elections, we decide too.

Up to four times a year. 50,000 signatures for a referendum, 100,000 for an initiative. Next date: 29 November 2026.

TURNOUT · BRAZIL

80.8%

runoff, voting compulsory

SERBIA

about 69%

preliminary

SWITZERLAND

46.6%

National Council 2023

USA · MIDTERMS

to follow

average since 1944: about 42%

Here too: in 2023 the Federal Statistical Office published wrong party shares and corrected them three days later. The seats stayed the same.

4 — OPEN DISCUSSION

What do you think?

💬 What builds more trust for you: fast and central, or slow and decentralised?

💬 When is it legitimate to question a result, and by what route?

💬 Would an election mean more to us if we couldn’t vote on issues all the time?

2:00

▶ Start timer

Time

5m

5 — TAKE-AWAY · BOTTOM LINE ★

“Elections are all decided in advance anyway.”

★ Claim your star now

Moderator: award the star →

Your kit for exactly that conversation:



What was elected?

Presidency, parliament, half-term? The word “election” doesn’t say what changes.



Which rule applies?

Runoff, proportional, districts: the same votes can come out differently under different rules.



Preliminary or final?

Poll, projection, interim count and official result are four different things.



Who can check it?

Who counts, who watches, where can you complain? Only then judge.

Time

5m

Bottom line → Master Checklist · Civics star ★ earned

The round

DEMOCRACY MATTERS

Merci!

The Learning Loop — design & concept of the gamified workshop format

Slides, quiz & star — everything to revisit

dmatters.org/content/elections.html

FOR THE MODERATOR

Run sheet

Run sheet on your phone

before	**Print** and cut the slips (A left, B right). No slips: read A to the left half while the right half closes their eyes, then the reverse. Check: are the USA and Serbia results entered?
15:00 (5′)	**Warm-up** — QR slide, **open the beamer view**, play the 3 questions. The app shows the explanations.
15:05 (5′)	**Experiment** — slips, read silently, 1–5 fingers, then the check slide: which countries were they?
15:10 (7′)	**Three cases** — the grid, then Brazil, Serbia, USA, just under two minutes each, Switzerland last as information. Read only the “Who believes the result?” card in full.
15:17 (5′)	**Discussion** — open round, no group task. The moderator takes no side and rates no candidate.
15:22 (5′)	**Take-away** — kit, bottom line onto the Master Checklist, Civics star ★. Never cut. Then buffer, the round.

Details: docs/runbook-elections.md · To revisit: …/content/elections.html